

20 The social origins and uses of media and communication research

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- a presentation of several *types of theory* that link research to social practice
- a review of *normative theories* of media
- an account of media and communication research as a *social institution*
- a description of the main applications of media research in *policy* and *politics*
- a discussion of *ethics* and *logistics* as aspects of the interchange between *researchers*, the rest of the *academic community*, *respondents*, and the *public* at large

THEORIES IN PRACTICE

Making public

This final chapter returns to some of the ‘big’ issues that motivate both individual media researchers and the commercial and public organizations housing and funding them. Why study the media? (Silverstone, 1999). Media are sources of both meaning and power. Like their objects of analysis, media studies originate from particular historical, cultural, and institutional circumstances; they contribute to shaping the conditions under which communication will take place in the future. If media are institutions-to-think-with, university departments and other research units constitute second-order institutions-to-think-with, describing, criticizing, and reflecting on the role of media in society – past, present, and future.

► media as institutions-to-think-with – Chapter 1, p. 17

Media and communication research participates in a double hermeneutics (Giddens, 1979) by interpreting media – their institutions, discourses, and users – and feeding those interpretations back into society at large. One implication of hermeneutics is that all human and social practice is informed by ‘theories’ – generalized conceptions of what the world is like and how we may engage it, individually and collectively (Lobkowitz, 1967). Whereas researchers are often, sometimes deservedly, perceived as too theoretical – detached from the world of practical affairs – “nothing is as practical as a good theory,” as suggested by one of the founders of media studies, Kurt Lewin (1945: 129). By examining the different types of theory that media professionals, legislators, and ordinary users hold and act on, communication research can make a practical difference.

double
hermeneutics

Researchers publish. Publication in journals and at conferences, however, is only one way of presenting findings and

publication:
research into
social practice

insights. To make research public is to make it available and accessible for social use. The audiences of research can be large or small, specialized or general, representing consensual or oppositional views of society, and assessing its relevance in either the short or the long term. Among the key audiences are media businesses that pay not only to have studies conducted but to make sure, for competitive reasons, that findings are *not* published. The further effects of media research, like those of media, are diverse and difficult to predict; they include unanticipated – and unrecognized – consequences for the media, their users, and for researchers themselves.

Following a brief account of five different kinds of theory, this chapter first reviews the so-called normative theories of media, addressing how media ought to operate. Those theories have fueled the rise and subsequent transformations of the modern mass media, and they still motivate much contemporary research. The next section traces the development of media and communication research. The intellectual cultures driving its academic and commercial variants have emphasized, to varying degrees, either ‘policy’ or ‘politics’ – concrete collaborations with the end users of research or long-term contributions to understanding, and perhaps changing, the role of media in society. Qualitative as well as quantitative approaches enter into studies from both policy and political perspectives – methodological boundaries, to a degree, dissolve when it comes to the social uses of media and communication research. In conclusion, the chapter reviews a number of political, ethical, and practical issues that arise in planning and conducting media studies – from student projects to national and international research programs.

Five types of theory

In his classic textbook, Denis McQuail (2010) laid out five types of theory addressing media and communication:

- *Scientific* theory is the most common understanding of ‘theory.’ It refers to general explanatory concepts and models that apply to a specified set of empirical instances. Historically, it has been associated particularly with natural sciences and with social-scientific research traditions that rely on surveys, experiments, and other quantitative methodologies;
- *Cultural* theory is the legacy of arts and humanities. It covers textual, historical, and other qualitative approaches to the interpretation and social uses of media;
- *Normative* theories address the legitimate ends and means of organizing media as a public infrastructure of communication. As such, they occupy a middle ground between scholarship and public debate and policy;
- *Operational* theory is made up of rules of thumb and sometimes tacit knowledge that (media) practitioners hold, including professional and ethical standards (Schön, 1983);
- *Everyday* theory, finally, underlies the common human practice of communication – our interaction with media institutions and with each other as citizens, consumers, and sources of information in our own right. While it often remains an implicit, practical consciousness, everyday theory may be articulated through research.

Academic communication theories are, in one sense, much less important than other types of theory – neither media professionals nor media users need explicit or abstract theories in order to communicate. McQuail’s typology itself illustrates the grounding of theories in practice. It emerged *ad hoc*, not as “a systematic, empirically grounded typology. . . . It developed gradually as a way of describing what I was doing and accounting for different ways of thinking about mass media” (personal email

► practical consciousness – Chapter 8, p. 164

lay theories

communication, March 20, 2007). In preparing the first edition (McQuail, 1983), he was especially concerned that everyday or commonsense notions of media and communication be included as a kind of theory. Lay theories (Furnham, 1988) are indispensable guides to everyday life. The academic definitions of what counts as (scientific) theories themselves change over time. In the fifth edition of the textbook (McQuail, 2005), the original four types of theory had become five: Cultural theory now appeared in parallel with (social) scientific theory. While rooted in the social sciences, McQuail recognized the two “as having more or less equal weight. I suppose this does reflect an obvious development and greater integration of the ‘field.’”

A common denominator for the five types of theory is that they enable action – in media research, production, policy, education, and public debate. The interrelations between the five types are of special interest in a field that has developed, in important ways, as a practical discipline that understands itself as solving communication problems. As such, communication research has the opportunity to affect journalism and other media production (operational theory) as well as educational programs advancing media literacy (lay theory).

Normative conceptions of communication occupy a special place at the juncture of theory and practice. Like academic theories, they are general. They assess the pros and cons of different ways of organizing media and communicative practices on a macrosocial scale. Unlike academic theories, normative theories of media involve the general public in assessments and deliberations. In addition to classic discussions concerning a commercial free press, a publicly funded broadcasting system, or an open-architecture internet, normative considerations bring up the ideological and existential implications of communication: the meaning of communication, as in ‘the meaning of

life’ (Jensen, 2008: 2803). Political and existential aspects of communication are the questions that most people care most deeply about.

communication as a political and existential issue

NORMATIVE THEORIES

Normative theories illustrate how ideas with a long history can be mobilized for contemporary purposes. Some of their constituents date from the Renaissance and the Enlightenment, even from the Socratic dialogue as an avenue toward truth and doing what is morally good. As currently defined, the normative theories of media and communication were formulated in the shadow of the Cold War. Also in communication research, that period pitted different models of society against each other. The classic publication (Siebert et al., 1956) identified four theories, with special reference to the printed press:

the Cold War

- *Authoritarian theory.* The medieval understanding of public communication took for granted a cosmology – at once social and religious – in which everything had its rightful place and where information flowed top-down from the monarch, the representative of divine authority on earth. This so-called Great Chain of Being ◀ – or pyramid – could be understood as enabling individuals to flourish en route toward their destiny. Only especially reliable individuals were allowed to disseminate information on any social scale, still subject to censorship. Audiences were just that – recipients of messages from political and religious authorities who knew better. While rarely advocated as such, authoritarian media theory provided a point of departure from which the other theories would distance themselves in distinctive ways.
- *Libertarian theory.* It was liberal theories of politics and communication

► the Great Chain of Being – Chapter 2, p. 32

that first came to challenge authoritarian models. Liberalism informed the larger shift from traditional to modern social structures, as articulated in and symbolized by the public sphere. ◀ Not only were humans redefined as ends in themselves, with certain inalienable political, economic, and cultural rights; humans were also conceived as rational animals with the capacity to collectively define and administer such rights. One unifying metaphor became the ‘marketplace of ideas’ (Peters, 2005), suggesting both that ideas might be advertised, bought, or declined in a market of sorts, and that the economic market for goods and services could advance this cultural and political process. Free enterprise and the competition of ideas, arguably, would benefit the public interest and the common good.

- *Totalitarian theory.* The occasion for formulating the normative theories, as noted, was the Cold War, specifically the implementation of a totalitarian or communist theory of the press in a number of countries following World War II. The distinction between totalitarian and authoritarian theory (and their relationship to 1930s fascism) has been debated. A central characteristic of totalitarian theory, however, was the understanding of central control over the media as a means of fundamentally restructuring society rather than preserving an existing social pyramid. Centralized state control, moreover, applied to all means of production, whether it was meaning or material goods being produced. Whereas the communist press systems in Europe broke down after 1989, in the People’s Republic of China, the Party-state remains in control of the main media.
- *Social responsibility theory.* After 1945, a growing concentration and

conglomeration of media called into question the classic liberal notion of a ‘free press.’ In the case of radio and television, the number of channels was further limited, at least for a period, by the available bandwidth. More generally, because their operation requires significant economic resources and professional skills, mass media have tended to be few and large. In response, normative theory witnessed a shift of emphasis from liberal and free-market ideals toward an understanding of the press and other media as trustees, or representatives of the general public, that ought to exercise social responsibility. European public service broadcasting represents a particular type of media that embody social responsibility theory. Other instances include quality newspapers that could be said to deliver “public service for private money” (Lund, 2001: 41).

public service
broadcasting

Formulated in the 1950s, the four types of normative theory seemed less applicable to some later media developments. Specifically, media systems in the developing world and media that facilitate public participation – from community radio to the internet – prompted the formulation of two additional positions (McQuail, 1983):

- *Development theory.* In the wake of decolonization, the 1960s witnessed renewed debates about media in the ‘Third World’ (while the other two ‘worlds’ were confronting each other in the Cold War). As also addressed in theories of intercultural communication, cultural imperialism, and postcolonialism, ◀ the issues included structural inequalities as well as imbalances in the flow of news and entertainment in the world. Interests in the

1989

area were complex and often conflicting: The generally desirable ‘free’ flow of information in the world must be weighed against the rights of states and nations to shape their own media systems and to gain a hearing in world media. At the same time, references to ‘free flow’ and ‘self-determination’ could be used as fronts for either economic expansionism or the silencing of critical voices locally. While difficult to articulate as one normative position or theory, development communication has continued to generate both research and public debate. Studies have identified a persistence of digital divides, for example, both between and within countries and at several levels: A distinction is commonly made between a first-level divide concerning basic access to the internet and other digital resources and a second-level divide of literacy, which suggests that access without the relevant interpretive and communicative skills still leaves many users at a significant disadvantage (Büchi, Just, & Latzer, 2015; Litt, 2013), with a third-level digital divide focusing attention on the (lack of) outcomes of internet use in terms of enhanced political, economic, or cultural participation (for overview, see Scheerder, van Deursen, & van Dijk, 2017) (for a global comparative study, see Ahmed, Cho, Jaidka, Eichstaedt, & Ungar, 2020);

- *Democratic-participant theory.* Particularly in the western world, the 1960s witnessed a second type of social upheaval, centered in anti-authoritarian movements that engaged in social and cultural criticism as well as political mobilization. On the one hand, the quality and diversity of the mass media was being questioned once again. On the other hand, new information and communication technologies offered cheaper and more accessible means

of political and cultural expression (Enzensberger, 1972/1970). Just as social-responsibility theory had identified the limitations of liberal press theory, democratic-participant theory pointed to a lack of social responsibility in the practices of mainstream media. The participatory ambition fueled various print and electronic grassroots media (Downing, 2000; Glessing, 1970), and it gained new momentum with reference to the interactive potentials of the internet (Jenkins, 2006; Rheingold, 1994).

Research has continued to develop and debate normative media theory (Christians, Glasser, McQuail, Nordenstreng, & White, 2009; Nerone, 1995), with implications for national, international, and intercultural communication. One difficulty of assessing the relative merits of the various positions has been the vagueness of some of the key concepts that they share, specifically the ‘freedom’ of media in relation to both state and market, and the ‘rights’ of individuals, groups, and private and public organizations to communicate. As noted by, among others, Jürgen Habermas (1989/1962: 226) in his classic treatise on the public sphere, rights come in two main variants – positive and negative. Whereas some political theorists and practitioners have advanced a negative definition (freedom *from* state interference into the affairs of individual citizens), others have emphasized a positive definition (freedom *to* require certain provisions and services from the collective). A negative definition had marked the transition to the modern period as, from the eighteenth century, the new middle classes reasserted their rights in opposition to the authority of the state. A positive redefinition, involving more substantial economic regulation and social services along Keynesian principles, was the outcome of world economic crises in the late nineteenth century and during the 1930s. More recently, a positive

from negative
to positive
definitions of
freedoms and
rights

privacy

conception of communication as a human right has been manifest in international research and public debate (Tumber & Waisbord, 2017). A specific focus of concern has become privacy, in the face of the surveillance of users as a standard operating procedure in digital communication systems.◀ (On privacy as a normative as well as conceptual issue, see, e.g., Baruh, Secinti, & Cemalcilar, 2017; Nissenbaum, 2011; Trepte et al., 2017.)

When considering positive and negative rights of communication (and other social interaction), one should keep in mind that current research, policy, and public debate address highly regulated societies and media. The relevant question is not so much the presence, absence, or *degree* of regulation – ‘less state interference, more freedom of expression’ – but the *kinds* of regulation that apply to different types of media at various levels of social organization – from legislation supporting national film production to international agreements on the internet as a business. Also in the future, media and communication researchers will be asked to assess who benefits most from specific conceptions of the general right to communicate – which was included in the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights (www.un.org/en/universal-declaration-human-rights/index.html, accessed November 15, 2020). The ‘four-plus-two’ normative theories continue to provide useful reference points for clarifying some of the abstract political, economic, and cultural ideals that inform public and policy debates.

The normative theories represent, in pragmatist terminology (Perry, 2001), beliefs that individual communicators, media corporations, and entire societies will be willing to act on. Roughly since the 1956 formulation of the normative theories, the field of media and communication research has established itself as a

social institution with diverse instrumental and reflective uses, and with normative implications. The field emerged at several crossroads of theory and practice, state and market, and conflicting intellectual currents.

MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION RESEARCH AS A SOCIAL INSTITUTION

Intellectual cultures

In a classic statement on theory and practice, Karl Marx noted, in his *Theses on Feuerbach* (1845), that “The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways; the point, however, is to change it.” While individual researchers may see themselves as administrators, reformers, or, occasionally, revolutionaries, research as an institution necessarily participates in shaping and maintaining modern society. Over time, a great deal of basic research comes to be applied. Compared, however, to a widespread nineteenth-century notion of science as a means of both material and cultural progress, much twentieth-century research found itself struggling with its sense of a mission. For one thing, the complicity of research in world wars, colonialism, and debatable forms of social engineering raised profound doubts about the traditional legitimacy of institutions of learning. For another thing, the growing availability and accessibility of information through mass media meant that the status and social uses of research lent themselves to increased and intense public scrutiny.

Media and communication research took shape after 1945 at the juncture of several intellectual and disciplinary cultures. The history of the modern university (Fallon, 1980; Rudy, 1984), in one aspect, is the history of reality being partitioned into manageable domains, to be studied through increasingly specialized theory and methods and to be managed in practical affairs by specialist graduates

basic and
applied
research

► surveillance and/as communication – Chapter 10, p. 208

from these domains. Following the founding of the modern research university in the early 1800s, the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries had witnessed the establishment of social sciences as a separate faculty alongside the humanities. A recognizable specialty of (mass) media research emerged from the 1930s, as witnessed by the early ‘milestone’ studies that are laid out Figure 9.1.

It was not until the 1950s, however, that an institutionalization of the field occurred, centered internationally in the social sciences but in diverse national configurations (Resource Box 20.1). Studies began to accumulate a distinctive body of findings, theory, and methodology. During the same period, humanities departments, including film, literature, linguistics, and history, similarly prepared important contributions to the field. They did so both by extending their domain of interest beyond high arts and histories emphasizing the classic institutions of political and economic power, and by revising their analytical procedures and theoretical frameworks. Following the anti-authoritarian upheavals of the 1960s, which questioned both establishment uses and disciplinary boundaries of research, a process of interdisciplinary convergence across social-scientific and humanistic traditions gained momentum from the 1980s, while collaborations with partners in public administration, private business, and civil society were consolidated and diversified.

One continuing debate has considered whether media and communication research constitutes an established (or emerging) discipline or a more loosely configured interdisciplinary field (for overview, Levy & Gurevitch, 1994). Regardless of nomenclature, there is no doubt that the field has a permanent presence in academia, in the media themselves, and

in other social institutions; the indicators include university departments, scholarly journals, conferences, consultancies, and participation in public debate. At the same time, it should be recognized that the field has remained heterogeneous. First, summative studies have suggested the existence of three relatively self-contained literatures, representing social sciences, interpretive studies, and critical analysis (Fink & Gantz, 1996). Second, other analyses have found that, at least in journal publications, quantitative studies continue to outnumber qualitative ones, that combinations of the two and of interdisciplinary perspectives are surprisingly rare, and that US scholars still dominate publications in the field (Kamhavi & Weaver, 2003; Trumbo, 2004; Walter, Cody, & Ball-Rokeach, 2018). Third, until quite recently, communication study has consisted of two separate subspecialties, focusing on interpersonal and mass communication (Rogers, 1999). Last but not least, digital media have recently produced increased interest in research across the mass and interpersonal prototypes, both in existing flagship journals and in new journals (Günther & Domahidi, 2017; Tomasello, Lee, & Baer, 2010); digital media also provide specific opportunities for research across traditional qualitative-quantitative and online-offline divides (Jensen, 2011).

In his frequently cited account of divisions within academia, C.P. Snow (1964) identified two separate, even opposed cultures, represented by “the literary intellectuals” and “the physical scientists” (p. 4). The social sciences occupy a third position, sometimes a middle ground. Humanistic, natural-scientific, and social-scientific research traditions generate specific forms of knowledge about different reality domains, each with characteristic social uses. Furthermore,

interpersonal
vs. mass
communication

arts and
sciences

field or
discipline?

► the modern research university – Chapter 2, p. 25
► social sciences as a separate faculty – Chapter 3, p. 55

► humanistic, natural-scientific, and social-scientific models of communication – Chapter 1, p. 11

RESOURCE BOX 20.1 HISTORIES OF MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION RESEARCH AS A FIELD

In recent decades, more historical accounts of the development of the field have begun to appear (for overview, see Park & Pooley, 2008; Simonson, Peck, Craig, & Jackson, 2013a). While such publications bear witness to the fact that media and communication research has been consolidated, both as an academic discipline and as a social institution, its origins and implications have remained contested. In overview, two main tendencies internationally have been the centrality of US social science in setting research agendas around the world since the 1950s and a more recent move, since the 1980s, toward a convergence of social-scientific and humanistic traditions.

Debates reflect the various administrative and critical, functionalist and emancipatory positions that have informed the field from the outset, theoretically and politically; history is being claimed and written by several self-defined victors. In addition, different national and regional research traditions have emerged. The following sources offer a variety of accounts and reflections on the development of the field:

- *The International Encyclopedia of Communication*. This milestone reference work (Donsbach, 2008) includes overviews of developments in different regions of the world, under the common heading of 'Communication as an Academic Field.'
- *North America*. As a prime mover of international communication studies, North American research has produced some of the most comprehensive – and contested – accounts of itself. Following an early contribution by Delia (1987), the 1990s witnessed a number of interventions in the genre of 'remembered history,' as told by key figures in the field. Wilbur Schramm, widely considered the central figure shaping and institutionalizing communication studies in the United States, published a personal memoir, supported by perspectives from Steven M. Chaffee and Everett M. Rogers (Schramm, 1997). Dennis and Wartella (1996) presented an edited collection with contributions from several central US figures, including accounts of the roots of the field in Europe and in Chicago School sociology. In a review of that volume, Hanno Hardt (1999) suggested that this 'remembered history' by key individuals served more as professional position statements than as an analytical historiography. In a monograph, Hardt (1992), in contrast, emphasized critical and interpretive aspects of US communication studies, linking these to philosophical pragmatism and to the wider intellectual history of the United States. Recently, more researchers have revisited and, in part, rewritten the North American history of the field, as exemplified by contributions in Park and Pooley (2008). Karin Wahl-Jørgensen (2004) documented important interdisciplinary sources and tendencies before – and in contrast to – 'the founding of the field' by Schramm. In addition, studies have recovered unrecognized contributors to and shapers of the field (e.g., Malin, 2011), specifically some of its 'founding mothers' (Rowland & Simonson, 2014) (see also Dorsten, 2012).
- *Europe*. Compared to North America, media and communication research in Europe has been shaped, to a degree, by differences between countries – in their media systems, academic traditions, and national cultures (McQuail, 2008). Vroons (2005) offered an overview of the different starting points in the mid-1950s. Nevertheless, European research can be characterized as a crossroads between significant US influences and a variety of humanistic sources and critical perspectives.

cont.

Together, current European and North American communication research can be taken as an international ecosystem in which studies are characterized more by theoretical and methodological traditions that span the continents than by their origins in national academic cultures.

- *Asia.* The field of communication naturally gives rise to considerations about national, regional, and cultural specificities, ◀ first, of the media and, second, of research *about* media and the communicative practices they afford – its methodologies, epistemologies, and ontologies. While such considerations are ongoing, to varying degrees, in different regions of the world, research in east and south Asia, traditionally dominated by US approaches, has advanced debates about whether and how to ‘de-westernize’ communication research. A collection edited by Georgette Wang (2011) included a range of perspectives from Asia, Europe, and North America on culture-specific and universal aspects of human communication and on the complementarity of different regional research traditions.
- *Central and peripheral countries.* Despite international flows of research, the published literature still exhibits a center-periphery structure in which authors from developed countries predominate over authors from developing or dependent countries. As noted by Marton Demeter (2018: 1001) regarding two separate circuits of publication,

Authors from dependent countries are underrepresented in the most prestigious journals, and, although authors from developed countries frequently collaborate with one another, their coauthorship with authors from dependent countries is idiosyncratic; therefore, authors from dependent countries tend to look for alternative ways to produce noticeable publications.

the three faculties have been associated with distinctive conceptions of epistemology and politics – how human knowledge of reality is possible in the first place, and why new knowledge should be produced. All scientific knowledge is interested in the sense that it serves (more or less controversial) human and social interests.

Knowledge interests

The concept of knowledge interests implies that purposes – sometimes implicit or unrecognized – are fundamental to any scientific inquiry. Importantly, knowledge interests are not merely reflections of the personal convictions of researchers or of the institutional agendas of their commercial or public funders. Knowledge

interests are constitutive of methodology and epistemology – the principles and procedures that guide different research practices.

While the notion is familiar from classic debates about human and social values in science and scholarship, the concept of knowledge interests was formulated as such by Jürgen Habermas (1971/1968). He distinguished three types, each relating to a particular reality domain and university faculty:

- *Control through prediction.* In natural sciences, a central purpose of inquiry is to be able to plan activities in the material world. Predictions and hypotheses that can be tested under controlled circumstances enable human intervention

into and, to a degree, control over nature. Modern experimental sciences have mastered the natural environment to an unprecedented degree by developing, refining, and accumulating criteria that describe and anticipate physical, chemical, and biological processes. As such, science has facilitated the management of natural resources, time, and space in social planning on a grand scale, notably in agriculture and industrial production. (*Media example*: Quantitative surveys predicting the preferences and trajectories of media users.)

- *Contemplative understanding*. In the humanities, scholarship has traditionally centered on cultural forms of expression that are examined by contemplation – interpretation through introspection. Artworks, for one, can be understood as ends in themselves that are analyzed for their immanent meaning and value. Historical events, for another, might bear witness to universal, even eternal aspects of the human condition, although the religious overtones of contemplating mundane events have gradually been downplayed. By disseminating their interpretations of cultural artifacts and historical events to the general public, humanistic scholars have served as the professional keepers of cultural tradition. (*Media example*: Qualitative studies interpreting media representations of social reality.)
- *Emancipation through critique*. The modern social sciences came to occupy a middle ground between natural and human sciences, addressing both material and experiential, collective and individual perspectives on social life. Because it is in a position to imagine unrealized potentials, Habermas suggested, the distinctive knowledge interest of social-scientific inquiry is one of human emancipation. By performing a critique of prevailing forms of social organization, and identifying

alternatives, the social sciences can promote the emancipation of humans from the conditions in which they find themselves. (*Media example*: Democratic-participant models of communication.)

The three forms of knowledge interest are, of course, ideal types, subject to a great deal of variation and combination in scientific practice. (Habermas later changed his position [Habermas, 1973], but his original account still offers a helpful comparative framework.) Habermas (1971/1968) further argued that the different knowledge interests do not transfer well from one reality domain to another. In particular, he noted, if the more technical knowledge interest of the natural sciences is pursued within the social sciences, their emancipatory potential may be lost. The argument is familiar from media studies that consider, for instance, television audience studies and the online tracking of internet users as means of social control (e.g., Ang, 1991).

It should be added that a critical knowledge interest does not equal, and does not necessarily entail, a specific ideological criticism of the social status quo. If criticism involves a rejection of what is and the identification of a preferred alternative, critique amounts to asking, what if? Like communication as such, research draws on the human capacity to consider how things might be different (Jensen, 2010). Also critical research is concerned with researchable, rather than merely debatable, issues, with a view to action. The relationship between knowledge and action has been approached in distinctive ways in different social sectors.

critique and/vs.
criticism

Sectors of research

The intellectual currents and knowledge interests of the field have fed variously into companies, organizations, and agencies that depend on research findings and insights as part of their operations. Early

on, Lazarsfeld (1941) pointed to two main purposes of media and communication studies:

- *Administrative research* refers to goal-oriented and instrumental studies that resolve specific issues for the purpose of developing, planning, or maintaining some communication activity, typically in the commercial sector. Studies in this vein “solve little problems, generally of a business character” (p. 8).
- *Critical research* addresses the wider social, cultural, and historical issues that technologically mediated communication raises, often from a user perspective and with reference to the public interest. Here, studies take up “the general role of our media of communication in the present social system” (p. 9).

When describing the critical variety of communication research, Lazarsfeld (1941) did so, in part, under the influence of the first generation of Frankfurt School scholars, who had fled Nazi Germany and continued their work in the United States. While fundamentally suspicious of “the culture industry” (Adorno & Horkheimer, 1977/1944) that they encountered there, the Frankfurt scholars did not simply reject US popular culture on ideological grounds. As suggested by the distinction between critique and criticism, one purpose of critical research is to identify the material as well as immaterial conditions of people’s beliefs about self and society, which, in turn, condition the status quo (Hammersley, 1995: 30). By reflecting on media as they currently exist, critical studies outline *what might be*. Lazarsfeld also noted this potential of critical research. And it was this quality that Habermas, who is commonly considered the central representative of a second generation of the Frankfurt School, specified as the characteristic knowledge interest of social science.

Lazarsfeld (1941) found that critical and administrative research could and should cross-fertilize as basic and applied forms of inquiry. His own accomplishments, centered in the Bureau of Applied Social Research at Columbia University, suggested the potential of that strategy. In addition to some of the early ‘milestones’ in media studies, he and his collaborators pioneered several methodological approaches, from panel studies to focus groups. Critical researchers, however, including European expatriates who, like Theodor Adorno, found a temporary home in Bureau projects, were mostly unsympathetic to administrative research (Delia, 1987: 52). Commercial and other instrumental interests, arguably, would narrow the theoretical scope of studies, limit their later social uses, and, in the longer term, undermine the intellectual freedom of researchers to choose both their research questions and their methods. Readers of the very last sentence of Lazarsfeld’s original article may have felt confirmed in the view that critical research was assigned the role of generating bright ideas to be exploited (financially and ideologically) in the administrative mainstream of research:

there is here a type of approach which, if it were included in the general stream of communications research, could contribute much in terms of challenging problems and new concepts useful in the interpretation of known, and in the search for new, data.

(Lazarsfeld, 1941: 16)

On closer examination, the two approaches to communication research exhibit a number of similarities and are often combined in practice. For one thing, both types rely on qualitative as well as quantitative methodologies – a fact that

► milestone studies – Chapter 9, p. 179

► panel studies – Chapter 13, p. 264

► focus groups – Chapter 14, p. 293

is sometimes missed in accounts associating administrative with quantitative, and critical with qualitative, approaches. In commercial settings, qualitative studies provide evidence that decision makers are willing act on to a significant extent. For another thing, both critical and administrative studies may be either reactive or proactive, evaluating what already is, or shaping what is not yet. Critical projects, in some cases, are the most instrumental of all, developing research designs to address inequalities of access to communication resources or in order to develop such resources. In cultural studies, some researchers have advocated more focused social uses of this tradition in policy contexts (Bennett, 1992), while others have called for a greater reliance on quantitative evidence to support the critical points of cultural studies (Lewis, 1997).

Figure 20.1 displays some main types of media research organizations, with national and cultural variations. The nature and output of research projects is explained, in large part, by the infrastructures embedding and enabling them – funding, organizations, time frames, and anticipated uses. Together, these infrastructures entail more or less administrative or critical practices, and different forms of reflexivity on behalf of research communities, commercial clients, political agencies, and the public at large.

As in other contemporary social life, a central divide exists between private enterprise and public service – commercial research entities and university departments. Even though the relative size of each of these main sectors of research is difficult to calculate, it is safe to say that commercial projects outdistance academic ones in terms of both financial resources and the number of studies undertaken. At the same time, commercial media and universities, in many countries, increasingly enter into collaboration: Universities fund (part of) their research through

commercial sponsorship, and media can base business development on research evidence, with an added bonus of legitimacy deriving from such collaboration. The research entities of public-service media occupy an additional middle ground.

The third type – independent research institutes – has been a staple of media and communication research since Lazarsfeld's Bureau, avoiding some of the negative connotations of both 'state' and 'market' and attracting clients from both sides of the divide. The fourth type – documentation centers – has more commonly been associated with historical, arts, and other humanistic archives than with empirical research on contemporary culture and society (although some film institutes have filled this role). At present, such entities are gaining importance, both as strategic resources in media production and planning and as a support function for affiliated research activities.

It should be added that the internet and other digital media have raised additional issues concerning the social production, organization, and dissemination of knowledge in society, including the relationship between proprietary and public-domain research (Benkler, 2006; Lessig, 2006). Such issues have gained new centrality in view of the collaborative, storage, and distribution capacities of digital media, as exemplified by open-source initiatives, file sharing, and peer production. One classic debate, familiar from public-service broadcasting, concerns the extent to which certain forms of knowledge should be understood as public goods (Samuelson, 1954), like water and electricity – from updated and reliable information about political issues and events to diverse analyses and reviews of the state of the economy. At stake, once again, are the interrelations and relative powers of different social agents and institutions representing market, state, and civil society.

reactive and
proactive
research

public goods

	Commercial company	University department	Independent research institute	Documentation center
Funding	Income from clients	Public or private funding	Commercial income and/or public funding	Commercial income and/or public funding
Organization of research activity	Management hierarchy	Autonomous researchers within (degree of) collegial government	Board of trustees and management hierarchy	Board of trustees and management hierarchy
Time frames	Days to years	Years to decades	Days to decades	Years to centuries
Anticipated uses of results	Strategic planning and product development	Description and critique of past and present media forms	Descriptive as well as proactive analyses	Description and documentation of media and communication institutions, contents, and uses
Examples	Marketing sections; Advertising agencies; Consultancies	Media studies departments; Schools of communication	Research bureaus and ad hoc centers; Thinktanks	Archives with proprietary and/or public (museum) access

Figure 20.1 Types of media and communication research organizations

The production and application of knowledge takes time. A distinctive feature of each of the four types of research organization is its time frame. Whereas commercial projects typically are scheduled for short-term instrumental purposes, academic studies suggest courses of action in the (very) long term. Research can be defined summarily as the collective representation of reality for a common purpose; the practical question is when, where, and how this purpose is to be enacted. Short-term and long-term purposes of research translate into three categories of social uses: policy, politics, and a third more indirect and diverse set of ‘stand-point’ interventions into social practice.

POLITICS AND/VERSUS POLICY

Policy contexts

Policies are codified plans of action. The importance of policy in both public

administration and commercial enterprise is a structural consequence of the increased complexity of modern societies, in material production, in organizational bureaucracies, and in politics from the local to the global level (Beniger, 1986). Collective and coordinated action depends on deliberation and planning through explicit policies; because of their scale and cost, policies, further, require evaluation and adjustment. Both the nature of such deliberations and the criteria of evaluation follow largely from predefined goals. Policies focus on specific contexts of action and on agendas set by existing social institutions. The area of policy research has expanded since 1945, one key figure being the communication scholar Harold D. Lasswell (Lerner & Lasswell, 1951).◀ The field of evaluation research (Patton, 2015), which examines organizational ends, means, and

evaluation
research

► Lasswell’s communication model – Chapter 1, p. 13

outcomes across the private and public sectors, can be seen as a variant of policy studies.

Media studies have contributed, from their inception, to planning and evaluating media and their performance. Three main policy contexts can be identified:

- *Business administration.* Within private enterprise, media employ in-house as well as commissioned research to support their business. In addition to audiences or customers, studies address the development of content, the internal work practices, and the strategic placement of the given organization in relation to competitors, regulators, and the general public (Scott & Lewis, 2017).
- *Public planning.* Compared to the more ad hoc policies of media businesses, public policy delineates the general frameworks in which media operate. A central area of influence for researchers is commission work leading into legislative and executive decisions, sometimes supported by specially funded studies. To exemplify, most European countries during the 1980–90s witnessed a great deal of commission work and research regarding satellite and cable technologies and their implications for public-service broadcasting (Blumler & Gurevitch, 1995).
- *Non-governmental organizations.* Beyond and between state and market, citizens' groups, thinktanks, and other organizations regularly develop and advocate particular policies. They do so with a view to a variety of stakeholders in politics and business, as well as the educational system. One example of civil-society involvement in international media policy is the Internet Governance Forum that followed the World Summit on the Information Society (2003–2005) (www.intgovforum.org/multilingual/, accessed November 15, 2020).

organizational
communication

state or
government
commissions

The three policy contexts – business, state, and civil society – correspond to the three columns of the public-sphere model of modern society. ◀ It is by engaging organizations and agencies in each of these domains – as collaborators or adversaries – that researchers may most directly affect the future infrastructures and conditions of communication in society at large.

Political processes

Compared to the relatively delimited *contexts* of policy, a second set of strategies shifts the emphasis toward certain less well-defined but potentially more far-reaching *processes* of change. Here, studies typically question or bracket current institutional agendas. (As in the case of policy contexts, both qualitative and quantitative approaches to media and communication research lend themselves to such political processes.) By critiquing and sometimes criticizing institutional logics, much academic research adopts a long-term strategy of change, seeking to identify the unacknowledged and sometimes covert interests driving either commercial or government policies. In this regard, academic media and communication researchers carry on aspects of the classic role of the intelligentsia that the sociologist Karl Mannheim described as relatively autonomous or 'free-floating' (Mannheim, 1976/1922: 136–146).

critical
role of the
intelligentsia

Corner (1991) identified two different political projects, originally within reception studies but with wider implications for media and communication research as such. On the one hand, the field has been broadly committed to Enlightenment ideals concerning the democratic accessibility of *public knowledge*, as typified by factual genres. From propaganda research to decoding studies of news to research on political debates online, an important research question has been how well

public
knowledge
project

media users are able to access and process the information on offer and to apply it in political and other forms of participation. On the other hand, particularly recent decades have witnessed much textual and audience research seeking to rehabilitate *popular culture*, especially fiction genres, as relevant and valuable resources of cultural participation and personal identity.

The central arenas of political influence for media studies range from various public-sector institutions to the public sphere as a general forum of social and cultural reflexivity:

- *Public debate.* Media and communication research regularly contributes to (and occasionally initiates) debates in the public sphere, its political as well as cultural domains (Figure 1.3). The interventions range from popular publications and interviews at the conclusion of projects to syndicated commentaries. In the process, researchers also feed the self-reflexivity of media, as they address contemporary issues such as political disinformation and lifestyle advertising. Through social media, researchers are in a position to participate more directly in public debates concerning the media field.
- *Media education.* Beyond their own graduate and undergraduate students, media and communication researchers have contributed to a democratization (or relativization) of the cultural heritage – canonic texts and other standards that inform curricula at various educational levels. In addition, the field has been successful, in a number of countries, in advancing a component of media literacy in general education (Hobbs & Mihailidis, 2019; Masterman, 1985; Messaris, 1994; Potter, 2019). This is in spite of the fact that the exact purpose and placement of media education (separately or within other subjects) has remained

debated. The ubiquity of digital media, along with more computer-supported learning, present additional questions concerning the definition of literacy and its implications for political and cultural participation. ◀

- *Museums and archives.* As suggested in Figure 20.1, documentation centers constitute a strategic resource for media research as well as media production. Also in a longer historical perspective, the preservation of contemporary media, their software and hardware, poses important public issues (Jensen, 1993b). One key question is whether and how the breadth and depth of modern media, including their everyday uses, will remain available and accessible alongside the high cultural forms that still reign supreme in museums and archives (and among employed archivists). If not, future scholars may not be able to (re)write the history of contemporary media or to reassess our theories and findings (Borgman, 2015). The Payne Fund (Jowett et al., 1996) and Mass Observation (Richards & Sheridan, 1987) studies of the 1930s suggest the value of such evidence for an understanding of media in their social and historical contexts.

Standpoint interventions

A third and more heterogeneous group of strategies share an explicit commitment to social and cultural change – in and through the practice of research, through alliances with particular constituencies or stakeholders, and in the (very) long term. Emphasizing political and epistemological alternatives to mainstream social uses of research, studies in this vein mostly rely on qualitative forms of analysis and argument.

Several of the strategies in question can be considered revolutionary rather than

reformist, at least in their own understanding. They are not only anti-establishment but, sometimes, anti-institutions, opposing the constitutive operations of, for instance, markets and families as they currently exist, even the very institutionalization of society. Some of them, further, advocate a radical break with the methodological and epistemological premises of other research traditions, which might be said to reproduce knowledge in the service of power. A common figure of thought and discourse is that alternative social arrangements are to be identified through alternative epistemologies. As theorized most influentially by Michel Foucault (1972), this argument shades into a position questioning the legitimacy of any and all forms of knowledge, a fundamental distrust of “power/knowledge” (Foucault, 1980).

power/
knowledge

Within media and communication research, it is particularly the cultural-studies tradition, broadly speaking, that has considered these strategies, generating debate with other research traditions (e.g., Ferguson & Golding, 1997). Since the 1970s, a great deal of work has taken other social and cultural research to task for articulating and promoting interests associated with the western world, the economic middle-class, the political mainstream, and a patriarchal mode of social interaction. One counter-strategy has been to treat knowledge in the plural, also terminologically, exploring alternative ‘knowledges’ in the interest of the disempowered. In response, other participants in these debates have argued that attempts by research to make up for past and present silences and injustices in society may result in political correctness (for overview, see Levy, 1992): Studies may be seen to shy away from certain controversial questions and hypotheses and may, as a result, produce less-than-robust empirical findings and theoretical frameworks. Unless scholars are allowed

political
correctness

to make claims to knowledge, however debatable and fallible, and regardless of their immediate legitimacy and relevance, the critical potential of research – for or against change – might be lost.

At least three kinds of standpoint interventions can be identified.

Feminist methodology

The term ‘standpoint’ derives from methodology and theory of science in the feminist tradition, as elaborated especially by Sandra Harding (1986). The premise is that all knowledge is produced from a socially situated standpoint, and that the life experiences of women – silenced in much of the history of ideas – provide a necessary corrective to other standpoints and in scholarship. Accordingly, feminist research might enable an enhanced or ‘strong’ objectivity by allowing women (and men) to transcend classic canons of objectivism and to take up (more) reflexive positions within the research process (see also Alcoff & Potter, 1993; Harding, 2004).

standpoint
epistemology

Compared to the biological essentialism that has characterized some feminist work, standpoint feminism represents an attempt to historicize the nexus between knowledge and power. In practice, however, the position may slide into another extreme of sociological essentialism, suggesting that feminism and cognate critical traditions offer more insightful theories and better empirical bases of change not because of the quality of the scholarship but because they tap the authentic experience of – stand on the shoulders of – the disempowered. In media studies, a related tendency can be found in work asserting that studies of women’s culture, of ethnic minorities, and of marginalized youth subcultures are the unrecognized origins of key ideas regarding the place of media in everyday life (Drotner, 1996: 41).

Feminist methodology and epistemology orient themselves toward change in

the long term. By reshaping the research institution and education, feminist studies may, in turn, help to reshape other social institutions. In doing so, feminist standpoint research can be understood as a socially situated practice within wider feminist movements.◀

Textual deconstructionism

A second, related position – deconstructionism – joins feminism in challenging unified conceptions of knowledge. Compared to feminism, however, deconstructionism focuses rather more narrowly on texts not only as a source of social dominance but also as the site of critique and change. Departing from poststructuralist theories of discourse and postmodernist conceptions of culture,◀ textual studies in this tradition seek to expose misrepresentations, or reified representations, of social reality by media.

Deconstructionism dissolves boundaries not only between text and reality but between the text being analyzed and the text performing and presenting the analysis. Like criticism in the arts, media criticism in this vein could be understood as an artwork in its own right. The work of the philosopher Richard Rorty has been influential in promoting a definition of research as one kind of story-telling (e.g., Rorty, 1979, 1989). Science and scholarship might be taken as one contribution to ‘the conversation of humankind,’ on a par with literature or journalism and without epistemological privileges. This view has been influential in parts of the literature on qualitative methodology, which, among other things, has emphasized an expansion of the range of genres in which researchers report their findings and tell their stories (Denzin & Lincoln, 2018).

► feminism as theory and practice – Chapter 2, p. 47

► poststructuralism and postmodernism – Chapter 2, p. 46

It is characteristic of deconstructionist media and communication studies that they rarely address empirical audiences or the social contexts in which texts are used, interpreted, and take effect. Instead, deconstructionist studies perform an interpretive reworking of media texts and offer their own preferred reinterpretations. While key publications have expressed revolutionary aims (e.g., Kristeva, 1984/1974), the likely agents of revolutionary or other social action have mostly remained unspecified. In practice, there appears to be an inverse relationship between the political ambition and the methodological detail of deconstructionism.

Given its comparative isolation from other social institutions, textual deconstructionism might have an impact in and through the educational system, which may trickle down to other social sectors. One specific area of impact is the media themselves, where notions of postmodernism have been widespread and where program developers have taken inspiration from deconstructionism (e.g., Caldwell, 1995).

Action research

A third type of standpoint intervention is action research, including several participatory and applied variants (for overview, see Bradbury, 2015; Greenwood & Levin, 2007). Like the other two types, action studies challenge established institutions and practices, sometimes in fundamental ways. Unlike the other types, action research emphasizes concrete and operational strategies for social change in cooperation with, or initiated by, stakeholders within the organizations in question, for example, for community development or workplace democracy. (Action research also incorporates quantitative approaches.) By involving everyday theorists◀ as partners in the formulation of research questions, as well as in research

► everyday theory – p. 413

procedures, studies become collaborative ventures of generating new and applicable knowledge.

In media and communication studies, action research has been less widespread than in community and workplace studies, education, and some other fields. Development communication programs included some involvement by the cultures and communities that were the end users of the technologies being diffused.◀ Also studies of community media◀ and of human-computer interaction (HCI) (Jacko, 2012) have relied on strategies involving end users. Given their participatory and broadly interactive features, digital media lend themselves to, and may stimulate, additional forms of action research (Hearn et al., 2009).

Like political and policy approaches to research, standpoint interventions return the field to the ‘big’ ideological and epistemological questions: Why study the media – with or on behalf of whom? In practice, in student projects as well as in comprehensive research programs, researchers face these questions as logistical as well as ethical considerations – which are addressed in the final section.

THE SOCIAL TRIAD OF RESEARCH PRACTICE

Research practice can be understood as a specific kind of social interaction, involving three key agents:

- the *researcher*
- his/her *respondents* (and other sources of evidence)
- the community of *peers* or colleagues who assess the quality both of findings and insights, and of the researcher’s professional conduct.

The social triad applies to studies across the various sectors and intellectual cul-

tures of media studies. It is through innumerable concrete interchanges within the triad that the field accumulates and adjusts a body of theory and evidence, simultaneously reproducing itself as a social institution on a daily basis.

Researchers’ relations with respondents and colleagues are examined in research ethics (for overview, see Israel, 2015) (on issues relating specifically to the internet, see also Franzke et al., 2020). Ethics, to one side, blends into *politics*. Politics articulates and enforces rules of human conduct at a collective or structural level, whereas ethics addresses standards of conduct in the perspective of the individual social agent. To the other side, ethics, as it applies to particular domains of social activity such as research, overlaps with *morality* – general standards of conduct that are prevalent in a historical period and cultural setting.

Certain aspects of research ethics are stated in legislation and codes of conduct, and are subject to enforcement by national authorities and institutional boards. Whereas the legal and ethical frameworks of media and communication research vary between countries, some of the main issues can be laid out with reference, first, to research subjects and, next, to the research community.

research ethics

Research subjects

Research subjects are just that – subjects. Unlike rocks and books, subjects can be harmed, socially and emotionally, by empirical studies. It is the responsibility of researchers to anticipate and prevent such harm and, simultaneously, to consider the beneficence of research – the good it may do. Research competence requires not only theoretical and methodological skills but also an awareness of ethical pitfalls, as established in previous work, and a general capacity for empathy and respect in encounters with others. It is worth noting that, for example, the International Communication Association only quite recently presented a code of ethics

► development communication – Chapter 11, p. 223

► community media – Chapter 11, p. 221

(ICA, 2019); other fields such as psychology and sociology have long offered detailed codes that can provide guidance for media and communication researchers as well.

The requirements of ethical research can be summarized as practical rules of thumb: “Do as you would be done by” and “Leave things as you find them” (Deacon et al., 2007: 377). The first principle is a variation on Immanuel Kant’s (2004b/1785: n.p.) categorical imperative: “Act always on such a maxim as thou canst at the same time will to be a universal law.” The second principle emphasizes the right of human subjects to self-determination. A researcher should not intervene proactively in a domain of study unless this is part of an explicit agreement, for instance, in action research.◀

the categorical
imperative

Depending on their research questions and concrete fields of analysis, empirical studies face various dilemmas. First, harm can take many different forms and may only manifest itself in the longer term. Although empirical media studies rarely pose issues of life and death, as in medical research, the disclosure of, for instance, documents concerning product development can result in significant losses, financially and in terms of the legitimacy of people within the media organization in question. Equally, the publication of politically controversial viewpoints from focus groups without sufficient anonymization may cause participants to lose social status or ‘face’ in their community.

Second, these examples further suggest that research subjects are vulnerable in different respects and to different degrees. In their reception study of women viewing mediated violence, Schlesinger et al. (1992) exercised special care in screening and debriefing their respondents, some of whom had been physically abused in their own lives. By comparison, in production and other organizational studies, informants are normally approached as

informants or representatives of a company or profession,◀ who are aware of this relationship and, to a degree, of the nature of academic research. Nevertheless, also in professional settings, ethical dilemmas arise when considering the appropriate means of serving the ends of research. A classic case in point is the undercover work of the Glasgow University Media Group (1976) in documenting and criticizing practices of news production within British television.

The standard procedure is informed consent. Its purpose is to enable subjects to agree or decline to participate in a specific study. The decision should be based on information about the elements of the study, its potential consequences for themselves, and its anticipated social uses. Informed consent is one key element of the Nuremberg Code (NIH, 1949), a set of protocols for research on human subjects that was established during the Nuremberg Trials on Nazi war crimes, which had included cruel scientific experimentation. While debated in terms of both its sufficiency and its practicability, informed consent represents a central operational principle in determining what (not) to do with research subjects. In medical and natural-scientific research, a standard procedure of double-blind experiments is observed (neither patient nor therapist knows who gets the active drug being tested and who gets the placebo). In comparison, informed consent aims for a standard of double insight that, ideally, also involves the objects of research as subjects.

informed
consent

double-blind
and
double-insight
procedures

When next reporting findings and conclusions, researchers face additional issues of confidentiality in general and anonymity in particular – issues that can be stated in terms of information and communication theory. In most instances, it is an ethical requirement that researchers preserve the anonymity of respondents by not communicating or *withholding*

confidentiality
and anonymity

information. In quantitative research, abuses may follow from a recycling and recombination of data sets, for instance, so that particular individuals are targeted in subsequent marketing campaigns. In qualitative research, harm is more likely to result when the readers of a report are able to identify a given individual through a rich contextual description. In both cases, the problem is not so much that the information in itself is publicized. (Such problems may occur when the information is proprietary, typically for commercial reasons, and hence confidential.) The problem arises if the communication by a researcher links the information to its original source. In most cases, neither qualitative nor quantitative methodologies depend for their explanatory value on such links. From the researcher's perspective, media practitioners and media users are of interest not as unique entities with biographical, demographic, and biological characteristics but as prototypes and as representative or illustrative instances of a social category.

From the sources' perspective, they have a right *not* to be associated with the information that they offer in the context of research. (In public communication, a comparable right has been referred to, in the European Union, as the right to be forgotten – a right *not* to be associated with long past statements or actions.) This right can be understood as a reverse copyright: Most media studies imply a social contract according to which subjects speak as types, not tokens – as an Anybody, not a Somebody. The principles of reverse copyright and double insight respond to the position of media and communication studies – and of social sciences generally – somewhere on a continuum between nomothetic and idiographic research – between studies of laws and of cases. ◀

Figure 20.2 outlines a set of guidelines for the conduct of empirical studies, with

implications for student projects as well as larger research programs.

The research community

A second set of issues within the triad of research concerns the relationship between researchers and their professional peers. As an ideal community, scholarship calls for the complete dissemination of all potentially relevant information as far as possible in global media of presentation. As an interested social practice, research requires individual scholars to weigh this ideal against anonymity and confidentiality requirements but also against material considerations such as intellectual property rights and their own careers. The research community is itself a social system of checks and balances, privileges and sanctions. The chief issues can be reviewed with reference to the different stages of the research process.

Especially in academic research, an early and decisive juncture is the approval of an empirical project by a national or institutional review board (IRB). In some countries, such approval is required before any study can be undertaken with human subjects and officially on behalf of a university. While debated along similar lines as the informed consent procedure, an initial review process provides some assurance that gross ethical misconduct will not occur. Next, the basic criteria of ethical research include intellectual honesty in the presentation of the sources of ideas, a complete accounting of successes and failures in data collection and analysis, and a systematic documentation of evidence and the bases of theoretical inference.

At their conclusion, research projects normally face a second review, typically in the form of a peer review – an anonymous (double-blind) evaluation by experienced researchers within the same specialization. This has been standard procedure in many fields since the mid-twentieth century and determines whether a study will be published in major journals. Once again, peer

Institutional
Review Boards

peer review

the right to be
forgotten

reverse
copyright

- 1 First make sure to ascertain the rules and procedures in your social and cultural context and academic institution regarding a preparatory *review* of research involving human subjects.
- 2 Always treat the people under study as – *people*. They are neither things nor texts. A standard procedure for ensuring their rights and preventing harm is informed consent.
- 3 Exercise *caution and concreteness*. Be prepared to give up a question (or an entire study) if, in context, it violates the ethical, cultural, or personal limits of the people involved. Be prepared to explain concretely the relevance of any question to informants and others.
- 4 Practice *reflexivity*. The analysis of (cautiously collected and concrete) data begins in the empirical field. In qualitative as well as quantitative projects, supplementary evidence and notes will support both the respectful use of respondents' contributions and the explanatory value of later interpretations.
- 5 Safeguard the *anonymity* of people and the *confidentiality* of information throughout the research process.
- 6 Be honest about the *sources of ideas* informing a study and the *contributions of peers* in developing and conducting it.
- 7 A research report includes accounts both of *process and outcome* and of *successes and failures* in each respect.
- 8 Two key requirements of a research report are a systematic *documentation* of evidence and an explication of the bases of theoretical *inference*.
- 9 Explore several different *publication formats*, including a means of *feedback* to the people contributing to a study.
- 10 Consider *what's next* – further research, the social relevance of findings, and the possible unanticipated consequences of the research.

Figure 20.2 Ten rules for the conduct of empirical studies

review has been the object of criticism, for example, for favoring entrenched traditions. Still, the procedure presents itself as perhaps the least worst alternative in the inevitably controversial enterprise of evaluating the quality of new contributions to research. In a further step, access to the original data sets of other researchers is a way of keeping the research community critically reflective and in dialogue. An example of debates arising from such a secondary data analysis was Hirsch's (1980, 1981) questioning of Gerbner and colleagues' cultivation hypothesis. ◀

The wider intellectual backdrop of media and communication research, during recent decades, has been intense conflicts – 'wars' – over the status and social uses of scientific knowledge. Within

the research community, science was flared up following Alan Sokal's hoax in a 1996 article (reprinted in Sokal & Bricmont, 1998) – a deliberately nonsensical publication that invoked the vocabulary of atomic physics and which was submitted to a major journal in order to expose the lack of scientific rigor in postmodern cultural studies and related traditions. Beyond the confrontations, this provocation also helped to generate insightful debates about epistemology and politics across theoretical and disciplinary boundaries (Ashman & Baringer, 2001; Labinger & Collins, 2001).

In the wider public sphere, two types of culture wars have been ongoing. First, especially in US public debate, orthodox (religious) and progressivist (modern) conceptions of humanity – what we can know and how we should act as individuals and

science wars

culture wars

societies – have been pitted against each other (Hunter, 1991). A second conflict continues to revolve around the relative aesthetic value and social relevance of high arts and popular culture, occupying and occasionally dividing media and communication researchers.

Intellectual conflicts with social implications are inherent in the study of media and communication, both from a contemporary and a historical perspective. A particularly bitter controversy that brought history into the present centered on the work of Elisabeth Noelle-Neumann (1984) on the spiral of silence. The theory suggests is that if people perceive their views to be in the minority as represented, not least, in the media, they are less likely to express these views. As a result, they come to participate in a circle or spiral of silence that is potentially vicious for democracy. One of Noelle-Neumann's specific arguments was that a predominance of leftwing views among German journalists and media helped to silence rightwing political views in that country.

Noelle-Neumann herself was quite explicit regarding her rightwing political sympathies and her work as a strategy adviser for the German Christian Democratic Party. However, following up on previous public criticism, Simpson (1996), in a *Journal of Communication* article, drew attention to her apparent sympathies with the Nazi party during World War II. Most importantly, Simpson linked the conclusions about a spiral of silence in the present with a set of theoretical assumptions and methodologies that had originally been developed for Noelle-Neumann's research in Germany during the war. In a fierce response, Kepplinger (1997) suggested that the critique was *ad hominem*. His counterargument, in essence, was that the quality of research methodologies as well as of the findings they produce can be judged independently of their origins and applications, past and present.

Whereas this particular debate was especially vehement and painful against

the background of world-war atrocities, the issue it raised is general: What is, and what ought to be, the relationship between scientific knowledge and social action? Like other forms of communication, researchers' deliberations about evidence, inferences, and potential courses of action necessarily come to an end.

THE END OF COMMUNICATION

In an imagined dialogue between two central twentieth-century American social scientists – C. Wright Mills and Paul F. Lazarsfeld – Stein (1964) pinpointed two approaches to social and cultural research. Mills reads aloud the first sentence of *The Sociological Imagination* (Mills, 1959): "Nowadays men often feel that their private lives are a series of traps." The fantasy imagines Lazarsfeld replying:

How many men, which men, how long have they felt this way, which aspects of their private lives bother them, do their public lives bother them, when do they feel free rather than trapped, what kinds of traps do they experience, etc., etc., etc.

(Stein, 1964: 215; discussed in Gitlin, 1978: 223)

The field of media and communication research continues to engage in such dialogue and debate concerning the comparative relevance and legitimacy of qualitative and quantitative methodologies. This can be considered part of the self-reflective business of any field; sometimes, self-reflection takes the form of self-criticism. While rooted in cultural studies, ◀ Morris (1990), for one, put this tradition on trial for banality, a solemn textual paraphrasing of the fact that cultures and societies are complex and contradictory phenomena. Ritchie (1999), for another, questioned the validity of much survey and other quantitative research

because of its ambiguous conception of probability.◀

What different traditions and temperaments typically share is an ambition of having research respond to real-life problems and concerns. Both Mills's sweeping generalizations and Lazarsfeld's mundane operationalizations assumed that, by describing and interpreting contemporary social and cultural conditions, research may make a practical difference. The orientation toward social action is a common denominator for research and (other) communication. Both media studies and communicative practices have ends – and they end.

the end of
communication
is to end

The end of communication, arguably, is to end: Ideally, having been enlightened and empowered through communication, individuals, groups, and institutions, as well as entire societies and cultures, go on to act. Political democracy is a case in point.

Michael Schudson (1997: 307), for one, has critiqued a . . . 'romance of

conversation' that confuses ordinary sociable conversation with problem-solving conversation, which is of a formal, rule-governed, and public nature. It is counterproductive, to the point of undermining political democracy itself, to think of public debate among citizens as just another conversation among either intimates or strangers. . . . At least as far as democracy is concerned, the response to the familiar rhetorical question, 'Can't we just talk about it?' must be: No.

(Jensen, 2010: 5)

It is the conclusion of communication and its transformation into concerted social action that is a hallmark of democracy.

Research, equally, comes to an end. The end of the research process is the beginning of other social practices. By reflecting on its origins, uses, and potential consequences, media and communication research can stake a claim to being both a scientifically mature and a socially relevant field of study.